For his critics Rajiv was a dilettante who tried to combine what Nehru and Indira did but lacked the depth of knowledge and steadfastness to stay on course. His spur-of-the-moment decisions, like his decision to send troops into Sri Lanka, often created long-term problems. His detractors critiqued him for listening to a small group of advisers – both bureaucratic and political – who were concentrated in his office and in India's external intelligence services.[127] Dixit, however, sums up Rajiv's years in power by stating that despite lacking in experience and faced with a changing world Rajiv successfully navigated India's national interests. [128]

AFTER THE DYNASTY

Rajiv Gandhi turned out to be the last prime minister of the Nehru-Gandhi political dynasty. Changes introduced by him paved the way for India's next steps during the 1990s but these were carried forward under different politicians who did not inherit the mantle of leadership from blood ties to Nehru. Internal economic problems, the end of the cold war and collapse of the Soviet Union led the Indian government to implement a series of economic measures that led to liberalization and less government control. The opening up of the economy also forced a rethink of India's foreign policy even though the left wing opposed both economic reform and international realignment. Many politicians, even within the Congress party, preferred the state-led model of economic development and objected to the expanded role of the private sector as a harbinger of greater corruption. They did not consider the emergence of the United States as the world's sole superpower as a positive development either. By 1989, Rajiv could not retain the wide political support that had led to his election in 1984. Dissidents from the Congress party, led by Vishwanath Pratap Singh (known as V.P. Singh), joined other left-of-centre factions to form the Janata Dal, which challenged Rajiv's Congress in the general elections of November 1989.